

Recognize it

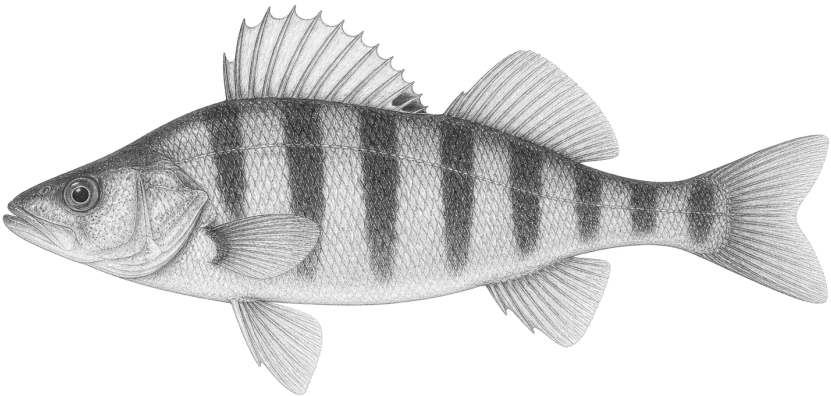
Golden fish with six to nine dark vertical bars and orange lower fins.

Body	Elongate panfish shape; two separate dorsal fins, first strongly spined.
Mouth/fins	Small toothed mouth; sharp gill-cover edge.
Confusion	Juvenile walleye is less golden, lacks orange lower fins, and has white tail tip.

Lake role

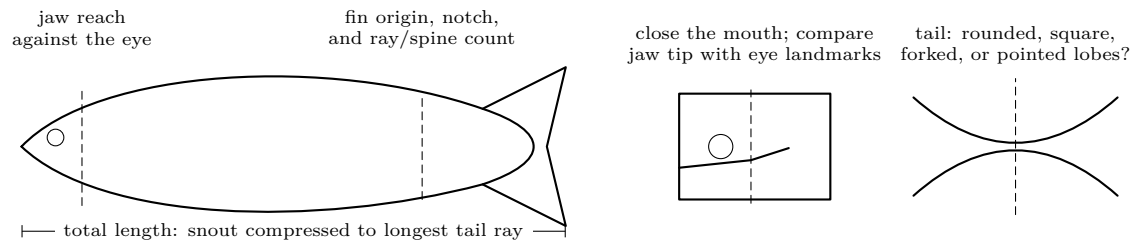
Where it belongs Weeds, sand/gravel, flats beside depth, and winter basin edges.
Food and season Insects, crayfish, and small fish; schools follow bottom prey and spawning routes.

Identification plate



Original graphite portrait for this ChatGPT edition. Morphology reviewed against Wisconsin DNR species references.

Read the fish before naming it



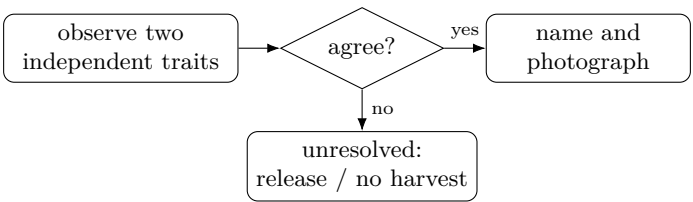
- 1. **Silhouette first.** Confirm the elongate panfish body and two fully separate dorsal fins.
- 2. **Hard structure second.** Check six to nine vertical bars and the absence of a walleye-style white lower-tail tip.
- 3. **Markings last.** Treat orange lower fins as supporting evidence because grayscale and age can obscure them.

Intermediate questions

Before looking at the species name, answer aloud: *Where does the closed jaw end? Are dorsal sections joined or separate? What is the tail-lobe shape? Which mark is structural enough to survive poor light?* If two answers conflict, record “unresolved” and do not force the identification.

Confusion-pair gate

Candidate	Yellow Perch
Nearest alternative	Juvenile walleye is less golden, lacks orange lower fins, and has white tail tip.
Required gate	Yellow perch requires separate dorsals plus barred sides and no strong white lower-tail tip.
Independent check	Compare tail tip, dorsal separation, and mouth size in one clean lateral photograph.



Find it on these waters

Pine	Test deep weed edge and firm flats; use electronics to avoid fishing beneath suspended schools.
North	Test weed-to-sand transitions, narrows, and basin-adjacent flats.
Evidence	The DNR lake records sometimes name only a broad group such as panfish. In that case this species is a candidate member, not verified individual presence. Confirm presence before targeting; treat locations as testable habitat hypotheses, not abundance findings.

Field evidence log

Date/time	Water + station	Depth/temp	Two observed traits	Habitat, lure, result
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Evidence threshold. One sighting is an observation, not an abundance claim. Repeat the same identification gate on another fish, retain a clear lateral photograph when lawful and safe, and note failed searches as carefully as catches. Two fish at the same depth suggest a school; log the depth before making another drop.

Presentations

1. **Small jig.** Tip with worm or small plastic; maintain bottom contact with short lifts.
2. **Spread search.** Use a float or slow drift until a school is found, then tighten the area.
3. **Stop rule.** One fish may be chance; two at the same depth is a pattern. If the school leaves, search again.

On-water verification
After the first response, ask: <i>Did the fish, depth, cover, and bite match the prediction?</i> Repeat once. If the second result disagrees, return to search mode rather than explaining away the evidence.

HANDLING DECIDES THE OUTCOME
Fold the first dorsal back carefully and avoid the sharp gill-cover edge.

Harvest decision · 2026–27

Water-specific rule	Open all year; no minimum; panfish daily bag 25 on both lakes as listed 2026-07-26.
Kitchen choice	Prefer thick mid-size perch; release unusually large females and stop when the meal is complete.
Before the trip	Open the Wisconsin DNR water-specific regulation page for WBIC 779200 (Pine) or 850800 (North). Check the exact water, species, and date; the live rule controls if this dated sheet differs.

Keep only a fish you can use
Decide before the cast. Bring ice, stop fishing when the planned meal is secured, and use the species-specific cooking guide for dispatch, bone layout, and safe preparation. Large old predators are valuable spawners and generally carry more mercury than smaller fish.

Sources checked 2026-07-26. Wisconsin DNR lake fish records (Pine WBIC 779200; North WBIC 850800), Wisconsin’s Fishes, Hook Your Catch, 2026–27 water-specific regulations, Catch-and-release Guidelines, and Eating Your Catch. Biological and tactical synthesis is editorial; it is not a current population survey.

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